Japan perceived a convergence of interests that lasted from the 1860s to the 1920s. This period witnessed other expressions of mutual support, including the despatch of Japanese marines to suppress an Indian mutiny in Singapore in 1915. There was even a formal Japanese military representative in India, with some of the attachés later becoming leading wartime generals. Japan was initially careful not to offend British imperial sensibilities and rejected any overtures to the contrary. It was only after this common ground eroded that it went on to become a base for Asian revolutionary activities. Remnants of this sentiment continued even after 1945, when their militaries cooperated in the attempted restoration of empires in South-East Asia. By every strategic logic, this approach should have continued. But it did not and therein lies one of the peculiarities of Asian security.

The causes for the non-strategic nature of modern India-Japan relations deserve introspection. Because, for all the ups and downs in Asia over the last seven decades, these two nations have a very limited history of policy exchanges, leave alone anything more. This distance between polities, whose natural interests should dictate otherwise, would normally be inexplicable. But we should remember that grand strategy could trump geopolitics in the era of the Cold War. Japan got drawn into the American security alliance, whereas India chose the non-alignment path. Particularly after India moved closer to the USSR, the sense of being on opposite sides of the Cold War was strong. There was, admittedly, a brief period in the late 1950s when some bonding was in evidence. But India’s defeat in the 1962 border war with China diminished its standing in Japan considerably. That country was part of the Western bloc’s cultivation of China after 1971 and this put India and Japan on even more divergent paths. In different ways, both harboured a fascination for China that led them to focus on that country to the exclusion of each other.

For Japan, culture was always central to the pull of China. After the war, it was also the focus of atonement for excesses. And very soon thereafter, a magnet which attracted outward-looking Japanese businesses. For India, there was the fraternity after decolonization until territorial differences made it untenable. The compulsions of a shared land border were themselves a powerful factor for intensive engagement. And in an earlier era where Western nations were busy undermining India’s integrity, China